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Baba of Karo, a woman of the Muslim Hausa

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The Death of my Husband, Malam Hasan the Warder; we move to New Giwa

When you are in mourning you boil water every Friday morning, you make it very hot, and you go behind your hut and wash your body; you come in and massage your body with oil. Every day you do your ordinary ablutions before you say your prayers, you wash your face, your feet, your underneath and your hands. The cloth and blouse and kerchief that you wore at the beginning of your mourning are not changed until the end of it. There is no Friday when you don't wash all over, but on the other days of the week you only do your ablutions. You wash your head thoroughly but you cannot cut your hair. You may go out in the daytime, quietly, to greet someone or to do some work. You don't have your hair dressed, every Friday you wash it and leave it as it is. You cannot go to feasts or naming-feasts or any ceremonies. You cannot rub tobacco-flowers on your teeth, but you can eat kolanuts—they are food, they aren't forbidden. You may put on antimony and you may shave round the edge of your hair to tidy it. When your husband dies, you must wail; if you loved him, then you are sad at heart also, he isn't there. If you didn't particularly like him, you wail because of compassion, you had got used to him and now he isn't here. Ah, Allah preserve us in health!

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Our husband died three years after Fagaci Ahmadu died. When he was retired from his work as Warder, another man came to do his work, Hasan a Barebare. My kinswoman Gambo was wandering on her own near Kaduna and there she met Hasan, this Barebare and he married her. When they brought him here to work and I saw her, I said 'Ap! And they said you had gone to the bad, you were just living on your own!' Her mother was my father's sister, we were joking relations. Her husband made some mistake and they dismissed him—it was said that he accepted money from prisoners and then left the

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door open so that they escaped. He went away to  213 Likoro, his own town, and farmed. They took their daughter 'Yarbaba with them; they are there to this day. Adama married a praise-singer, and she is living here in New Giwa; he is called Ibrahim Roko. Her co-wife is a *bori*-dancer who also does hairdressing; her *bori* is very good. Later I married Ibrahim Dantsoho, he farms but he has no hut for me in his compound, so I live in my younger brother's compound. (²⁶⁵) There are four of us, Dantsoho's wives. He gives me no food, I am here in my own compound.

Pitilli –not traceable botanically.

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